11,000 officers and men of 11 Corps, led by Lieutenant General P.K. Singh, an outstanding leader. Such a large gathering was some sort of a record. I was the army commander of Western Command and the chief of army staff-designate at that time. It was a very moving event for me.

We did well in many of these sports and professional competitions. I was able to train and motivate my company to a high pitch. Our focus was to be the best company of the battalion and we worked very hard to achieve our objective. Consequently, 'A' Company won the championship trophy for the year 1977. My sole aim was to earn the respect of my men and be remembered as one of the best company commanders. 'B' Company under Major M.N.S. Thampi was the one that gave us the toughest competition. Six years later, he succeeded me as the commanding officer of the battalion. One interesting aside during this tenure was that I nearly got assigned on the five-month-long battalion support weapons course. There was a vacancy on the course allotted to our brigade, and there was no junior officer available to go for it. Since surrendering of a course vacancy was not acceptable to the higher HQ, my name was forwarded. It was really a joke for someone who had done the Staff College and been a brigade major for two years, to be sent for this course meant for captains and lieutenants. All because I was below thirty-two years of age! Somehow, wisdom prevailed at the Division HQ and I was taken out of this assignment, although for me it would have been like a paid holiday.

Unexpectedly, the next summer I got a posting to a remote field area in Jammu and Kashmir, in the Tangdhar sector. It was graded as a 'high-altitude and uncongenial climate' area. I did not think it fair to be sent to an operational area once again, but I was told that 7 Maratha LI needed officers of my seniority to command companies deployed along the line of control (LoC), as the posted strength of officers in the unit had become very low. Some had been declared medically unfit and had to be moved out of the battalion. Therefore, during mid-1978, after the usual farewell dinner, I moved to join 7 Maratha LI. My wife and kids stayed behind at Jalandhar. This was my first posting to the LoC in J&K.